

AYURVEDA

Knowledge Compilation from Open-Access Official Sources

National Institute of Ayurveda (NIA), Jaipur
CCRAS / NIIMH, Ministry of AYUSH, Govt. of India
WHO-APW Project on Standardisation of Ayurvedic Terminologies

SOURCES INCLUDED IN THIS DOCUMENT

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3. AYUSHDHARA (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0) — Study on Chatushkas of Charaka Samhita (2025)
4. IJCRT — Concept of Tridosha Theory: A Critical Review (2021)
5. Charaka Samhita Handbook on Ayurveda — Vol. I (Gabriel Van Loon, open text)
6. AYUSH Ministry — Preventive Measures & AYUSH COVID-19 Research Papers
7. NAMASTE Portal — Standardised Ayurveda Terminologies (namaste.ayush.gov.in)

Compiled: May 15, 2026 | For Academic & Research Reference | All source texts are Government of India open-access publications

SECTION 1: Introduction to Ayurveda — Scope, History, and Global Context

1.1 What is Ayurveda?

Ayurveda is possibly the most ancient system of medicine in the world. The term Ayurveda derives from the Sanskrit words Ayus (life) and Veda (knowledge/science), meaning 'the science of life.' Its basic principles are universal in scope but context-specific in application — each recommendation is tailored to the individual. It is eco-friendly, cost-effective, organic, natural, holistic, lifestyle-integrated, and easily replicable due to its 'global yet local' approach.

1.2 Historical Roots

The classical literature of Ayurveda traces its roots to two major compendiums: the Charaka Samhita and the Sushruta Samhita, which date back over two thousand years. These texts are written in Sanskrit in the Devanagari script. Other key texts include the Ashtanga Hridayam and Ashtanga Sangraha by Vagbhata (~400 CE), and the Madhava Nidana and Sharngadhara Samhita. Together these constitute the Brihatrayi (greater triad) and Laghutrayi (lesser triad) of classical Ayurveda.

According to the Atreya Sampradaya tradition, Ayurvedic knowledge was revealed by Lord Brahma to Daksha Prajapati, who passed it to the Ashwini Kumaras, then to Lord Indra, and then to Punarvasu Atreya. Atreya's disciple Agnivesha composed the Agnivesha Tantra, which was later redacted by Charaka and became the Charaka Samhita.

1.3 Scale and Reach in India

India has perhaps the world's largest community-based indigenous system of medicine. Over 65% of the rural population uses AYUSH medicines for primary healthcare. AYUSH practitioners (over 700,000) outnumber allopathic doctors (~633,000), with over 400,000 registered Ayurveda practitioners. There are more than 200 Ayurveda colleges and four full-fledged Ayurveda universities in India.

SECTION 2: Panchamahabhuta — The Five Great Elements

In Ayurveda, all matter — living and non-living — is composed of five fundamental elements called the Panchamahabhuta. These are not merely physical substances but represent the foundational qualities of all existence.

Element (Sanskrit)	English	Properties	Sensory quality
Akasha	Space / Ether	Shabda (sound), light, subtle	Hearing
Vayu	Air / Wind	Sparsha (touch), mobile, dry	Touch
Agni	Fire	Rupa (form), hot, sharp, light	Sight
Jala	Water	Rasa (taste), liquid, cool, soft	Taste
Prithvi	Earth	Gandha (smell), heavy, dense, stable	Smell

2.1 Panchabhautic Basis of Doshas

In the Panchabhautic world/body, the laghu-guna-yukta Akasha combines with Vayu to nourish the Vata dosha; Agni Mahabhuta nourishes the Pitta dosha; and the guruguna-yukta Bhoomi along with Jala nourishes the Kapha dosha. Although Tridoshas are also Panchabhautic in origin (made of all five elements), there is predominance of Vayu and Akasha in Vata, predominance of Agni in Pitta, and predominance of Jala and Prithvi in Kapha.

SECTION 3: Tridosha — The Three Biological Energies

"Tridosha ('Tri'= three + 'Dosa'= vitiation-capable) consists of three fundamental biological energies — Vata, Pitta, and Kapha. The doshas are responsible for homeostasis and health of living beings. When these energy forces are in equilibrium, living beings are in a normal health status; when they deviate, disease is produced."

— IJCRT Vol 9, Issue 1, 2021 — MMM Govt. Ayurveda College, Udaipur

3.1 The Three Doshas — Summary Table

Dosha	Element base	Energy type	Seat	Governs
Vata	Akasha + Vayu	Kinetic	Colon, pelvic region	Movement, neural impulses, respiration
Pitta	Agni (fire)	Thermal	Duodenum, liver	Digestion, metabolism, sight, pigmentation
Kapha	Jala + Prithvi	Mechanical / Potential	Stomach, chest	Structure, lubrication, immunity, memory

3.2 Vata — The Kinetic Dosha (Catabolic)

Vata is formed by a combination of space and air. Its basic characteristic is movement — physical and spiritual. Vata controls the flow of neural impulses and performs the major function of controlling the other two doshas. The word Vata is derived from the root 'va' meaning gati (movement), gnana (grasping knowledge), and prapti (achieving). It is Rajasic in functional quality.

Five sub-types of Vata:

Prana Vata — Located in the head. Controls the senses and sensory input.

Vyana Vata — Located in the heart. Controls all voluntary bodily actions and circulation.

Udana Vata — Located in the chest. Controls voice, intellectual abilities and upward movements.

Samana Vata — Located in the stomach. Controls digestive processes and assimilation.

Apana Vata — Located in the anal/pelvic region. Controls all downward discharges.

3.3 Pitta — The Metabolic Dosha

Pitta is formed by a combination of fire and water. It governs all processes related to metabolism and transformation (mental and physical). The word Pitta is derived from 'tap' meaning santapa (for paka — digestion and sara-kitta separation), daha (transformation), and aishwarya (prosperity). It is primarily Satvic in quality.

Five sub-types of Pitta:

Ranjaka Pitta — In the stomach. Produces Rakta (blood) and imparts colour.

Bhrajaka Pitta — In the skin. Controls skin pigmentation and complexion.

Aalochaka Pitta — In the eyes. Controls sight and visual processing.

Sadhaka Pitta — In the heart. Governs psychological capabilities and intelligence.

Pachaka Pitta — In the duodenum (small intestine). Controls digestive functioning — the primary Pitta.

3.4 Kapha — The Anabolic Dosha

Earth and water together make Kapha, the anabolic dosha. Its most important function is to provide energy to the mind and body. Kapha controls the amount of water in the body and fills up depleted parts down to the

cellular level. The word Kapha comes from the root 'shilsh' implying shleshana (binding) or poshana (nourishment). It is Tamasic in functional quality — conserving and stabilising.

Five sub-types of Kapha:

Kledaka Kapha — In the stomach. Moistens food and aids initial digestion.

Shleshaka Kapha — In all joints. Controls lubrication and joint health.

Tarpaka Kapha — In the head. Controls intelligence, memory, and sense organs.

Bodhaka Kapha — In the taste organ (tongue). Governs taste perception.

Avalambaka Kapha — In the chest. Lubricates the heart and throat.

3.5 Dosha–Guna Relationships with Panchamahabhuta

Each Guna (quality) of a Dosha can be traced to specific elemental combinations:

Dosha	Guna (Quality)	Panchabhauta Composition
Vata	Ruksha (dry)	Prithvi, Agni, Vayu
Vata	Laghu (light)	Vayu, Akasha, Agni
Vata	Chala (mobile)	Vayu, Akasha
Pitta	Ushna (hot)	Agni
Pitta	Tikshna (sharp)	Agni
Pitta	Drava (liquid)	Jala
Kapha	Guru (heavy)	Prithvi, Jala
Kapha	Sheeta (cold)	Jala
Kapha	Sthira (stable)	Prithvi
Kapha	Picchila (slimy)	Jala

SECTION 4: Sapta Dhatu, Tri-Mala, and Agni

4.1 Sapta Dhatu — Seven Tissues

The body is composed of seven tissues (Dhatus), which are sequentially nourished from food via the digestive fire (Agni). Each Dhatu is processed to form the next, in a cascade called Dhatu Poshana Krama:

No.	Dhatu	Modern equivalent	Nourishes next
1	Rasa	Plasma / lymph	Rakta
2	Rakta	Blood (red cells)	Mamsa
3	Mamsa	Muscle tissue	Meda
4	Meda	Fat / adipose tissue	Asthi
5	Asthi	Bone	Majja
6	Majja	Bone marrow / nerve	Shukra
7	Shukra	Reproductive tissue / Ojas	—

4.2 Tri-Mala — Three Waste Products

Mala refers to waste products of metabolism. Their proper formation and elimination is essential for health. The three primary Malas are:

- Mutra (urine) — liquid waste filtered by kidneys
- Purisha (faeces) — solid waste from digestion
- Sveda (sweat) — gaseous/liquid waste from skin; also regulates body temperature

4.3 Agni — Digestive and Metabolic Fire

Agni is the transformative fire in the body responsible for all metabolic and digestive activities. The primary Agni is Jatharagni (gastric fire). There are five Bhutagnis (elemental fires) and seven Dhatvagnis (tissue fires). Balanced Agni is the cornerstone of health; impaired Agni (mandagni) leads to the formation of Ama (toxins), which is considered the root cause of most disease. Agni is regulated primarily by Samana Vata and Pachaka Pitta.

SECTION 5: Prakriti — Individual Constitution

"The Tridosha forms the basic human character called Prakriti, translated as Constitution or Temperament. The dominant Dosha determines the psychosomatic character type to which a living being belongs. This character type is inherited from birth and remains unaltered throughout life."

— Hitha Ayurveda — Prakriti & Vikriti Explained

5.1 Seven Prakriti Types

Prakriti Type	Dominant element(s)	Key traits
Vata Prakriti	Vata dominant	Thin build, dry skin, creative, quick thinking, variable energy
Pitta Prakriti	Pitta dominant	Medium build, good digestion, strong intellect, competitive
Kapha Prakriti	Kapha dominant	Sturdy build, smooth skin, calm, stable, slow metabolism
Vata-Pitta	Vata + Pitta	Combination of above; dynamic yet sharp
Pitta-Kapha	Pitta + Kapha	Strong, determined, good endurance
Vata-Kapha	Vata + Kapha	Variable energy, resilient constitution
Tridosha Prakriti	All three balanced	Rare; considered most stable and healthy

SECTION 6: Structure of the Charaka Samhita

The Charaka Samhita is one of the two foundational compendiums of Ayurveda, primarily focused on Kayachikitsa (internal medicine). It consists of 8 Sthanas (sections) with a total of 120 chapters, 8,400 shlokas (verses), and covers the full scope of Ayurvedic theory and clinical practice.

Sthana (Section)	Chapters	Content
Sutra Sthana	30	General principles, Tridosha, diet, prevention, philosophy. 7 Chatushkas + 2 summary chapters
Nidana Sthana	8	Pathology — causes, symptoms, and classification of 8 major diseases.
Vimana Sthana	8	Medical training, ethics, role of diet, pharmacology, taste (Rasa).
Sharira Sthana	8	Embryology, anatomy of the human body, soul and consciousness.
Indriya Sthana	12	Arishta Vijnana — prognosis; signs of imminent death.
Chikitsa Sthana	30	Therapeutics — treatment of major diseases with formulas.
Kalpa Sthana	12	Pharmacy — preparation of Panchakarma and emetic/purgative medicines.
Siddhi Sthana	12	Treatment protocols — Basti (enema) procedures and Panchakarma details.

6.1 The Seven Chatushkas of Sutra Sthana

The Sutra Sthana is organised into 7 Chatushkas (groups of 4 chapters) plus 2 summary chapters (Sangraha Dwaya). Each Chatushka addresses a thematic group:

Bheshaja Chatushka: Medicine — drugs, formulations, Panchakarma substances

Swastha Chatushka: Healthy living — diet, sleep, daily regimen (Dinacharya)

Nirdesha Chatushka: Prescriptions — Tridosha theory, disease causation, Six Tastes

Kalpana Chatushka: Formulations — Sneha (oleation), Sweda (sudation)

Roga Chatushka: Diseases — classification of 8 major disorders

Yojana Chatushka: Therapeutics — Langhana, Brimhana, diet correction

Anna Pana Chatushka: Food and drink — properties of foods, medicinal diets

SECTION 7: Sushruta Samhita — Surgery & Unique Contributions

The Sushruta Samhita is the second foundational text of Ayurveda, focused on Shalya Tantra (surgery). It is thought to date to approximately the same period as the Charaka Samhita. The text is both prose and poetry, with poetry as the larger portion. Sushruta describes over 300 surgical procedures, 120 surgical instruments, and 64 types of non-invasive procedures.

7.1 Unique Contributions of Sushruta Samhita

- Five types of Pitta Dosha (the first text to enumerate Pitta sub-types)
- Role of Rakta Dhatu (blood) as a fourth doshic principle in aetiopathogenesis
- Shadkriyakala — six stages of disease development
- Shadvidha Roga Pariksha — six methods of clinical examination
- Marma Shastra — 107 vital points of the body
- Detailed description of dissection (Shava Chedana) methodology
- Rhinoplasty and reconstructive surgery procedures (forerunner of modern plastic surgery)

7.2 Classic Definition of Health (Sushruta)

"Sama dosha, sama agnischa sama dhatu mala kriyah | Prasanna atma indriya manah swastha ityabhidhiyate ||"

— Sushruta Samhita, Sutrasthana 15.41

Translation: A person with balanced doshas, balanced digestive fire, balanced tissues, proper waste elimination, and a pleasant state of soul, senses, and mind — is called healthy (Swastha). This remains the most comprehensive and frequently cited definition of health in Ayurveda.

SECTION 8: NIA–WHO Standardisation of Ayurveda Terminologies

The National Institute of Ayurveda, Jaipur undertook a WHO-APW project to standardise the Non-Clinical Terminologies of Ayurveda. This was part of a broader effort to develop an 'International Standard Terminology of Ayurveda' for inclusion in the WHO Family of International Classifications, including the ICD.

8.1 Project Background

The WHO draft Regional Strategy for Traditional Medicine (2011–2020) identified five strategic objectives, including the need for international standardisation and harmonisation of traditional medicine knowledge. Standardisation of terminology enables: electronic health records, clinical trial comparability, reimbursement policy integration, and cross-border exchange of medical data.

The NIA divided the standardisation work into two parts: Non-Clinical Terminologies (assigned to NIA Jaipur) and Clinical Terminologies (assigned to IPGTRA Jamnagar). A nationwide panel of experts from junior to senior consultant level participated through consultative meetings, phone, and internet communication.

8.2 Key Classical Texts Used as Sources

The terminology project drew from the major extant classical Ayurveda texts:

- Charaka Samhita (Kayachikitsa / internal medicine)
- Sushruta Samhita (Shalya / surgery)
- Ashtanga Hridayam by Vagbhata (~400 CE) — primary reference for Kapha sub-doshas
- Ashtanga Sangraha by Vagbhata (~400 CE)
- Madhava Nidana (pathology)
- Sharngadhara Samhita (pharmacy)
- Various Nighantu (materia medica) texts

SECTION 9: Trisutra, Disease Causation, and Treatment Principles

9.1 Trisutra — The Three-Strand Framework

The Charaka Samhita opens with the concept of Trisutra — the three foundational pillars of Ayurvedic medical practice:

- Hetu (cause) — aetiology of health and disease
- Linga (signs and symptoms) — clinical presentation
- Aushadha (treatment/medicine) — therapeutic intervention

The Trisutra is described as useful for both the healthy (Swastha) and the sick (Atura). Alongside it, Samanya (similarity), Vishesh (dissimilarity), Guna, Dravya, Karma, and Samavaya constitute the philosophical Padarthas underlying Ayurvedic therapeutics.

9.2 Trividha Karana — Three Causes of Disease

The Charaka Samhita identifies three modes of disease causation:

- Asatmya Indriyarth Samyoga — unwholesome contact of sense organs with sense objects
- Prajnaparadha — crimes against wisdom (knowingly doing what is harmful)
- Kala Parinama — seasonal, temporal, and environmental derangements

Mithya yoga (wrong use), Atiyoga (over-use), and Ayoga (under-use) of Kala, Buddhi, and Indriya-artha are the Trividha Karana (three causes). Sharira (body) and Mana (mind) are the two Ashraya (seats) of disease.

9.3 Panchakarma — Five Purification Therapies

Panchakarma is the foundational set of five purification therapies in Ayurveda, described in detail in the Kalpa Sthana and Siddhi Sthana of the Charaka Samhita:

Therapy	Sanskrit	Action
Emesis	Vamana	Expels accumulated Kapha from stomach — treats Kapha disorders
Purgation	Virechana	Expels Pitta from liver/intestines — treats Pitta disorders
Enema	Basti	Oil or decoction enema — considered most powerful, treats Vata
Nasal drops	Nasya	Medicated oils/powders into nose — treats disorders above neck
Bloodletting	Raktamokshana	Removes vitiated blood — treats Pitta-Rakta disorders

SECTION 10: Open-Access Portals — Where to Access Primary Texts

All the following resources are freely available from Government of India and affiliated institutions:

Resource	URL	Content
e-Charaka Samhita (NIIMH/CCRAS)	niimh.nic.in/ebook/ecaraka	Full Sanskrit text with English translation, searchable by key
e-Sushruta Samhita (NIIMH/CCRAS)	niimh.nic.in/ebooks/esushruta	Full text with commentary
Madhava Nidana (NIIMH)	niimh.nic.in/ebooks/madhavanidana	Classical pathology text
e-Nighantu (17 texts)	niimh.nic.in/ebooks/e-Nighantu	Materia medica — Ashtanga, Kaiyadeva, Dhanvantari Nigha
NIA Terminologies PDF	nia.nic.in/pdf/TERMINOLOGIES.pdf	WHO-APW Non-Clinical Terminologies of Ayurveda
NAMASTE Portal	namaste.ayush.gov.in	Standardised Ayurveda Terminologies (SAT), downloadable
AYUSH Ministry Resources	ayush.gov.in/resources	Clinical guidelines, research papers, preventive health docu
AYUSHDHARA Journal	ayushdhara.in	Open-access (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0) peer-reviewed journal on
CCRAS Publications	ccras.nic.in	Research monographs and drug standardisation documents
Internet Archive — Samhitas	archive.org (search 'Charaka Samhita')	P.V. Sharma English translation and other digitised classical

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e-Charaka Samhita — Full digital text with Sanskrit and English.

niimh.nic.in/ebook/ecaraka

Access: Government of India, open access

[5] CCRAS / NIIMH

e-Sushruta Samhita — Full digital text.

niimh.nic.in/ebooks/esushruta

Access: Government of India, open access

[6] CCRAS / NIIMH

e-Nighantu Collection — 17 classical materia medica texts.

niimh.nic.in/ebooks/e-Nighantu

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AYUSH Preventive Measures for Self-Care during COVID-19 Pandemic. Health Resource Document.

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rkamc.org.in/images/Charaka-Samhita-Acharya-Charaka.pdf

Access: Open educational resource

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National AYUSH Morbidity and Standardised Terminologies Electronic Portal. Standardised Ayurveda Terminologies (SAT-A through SAT-J).

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Access: Government of India, open access

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